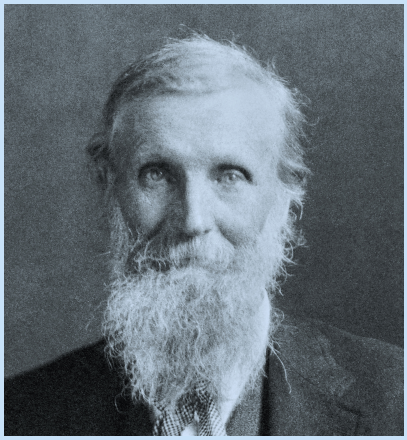
John Muir



Born in Scotland in 1838, John Muir developed a passion for nature as a boy. He moved with his family to Wisconsin at the age of 11. In 1867, he had an accident in which he lost his sight temporarily, after which he “saw the world in a new light.” An accomplished botanist, geologist, and glaciologist, Muir visited the Yosemite Valley in California in 1868, and later determined to preserve it from the scourge of domestic sheep (which he called “hoofed locusts”). In 1903, Muir took President Theodore Roosevelt on a guided tour through the Yosemite Valley, and their three-day trip inspired Roosevelt to create the US Forestry Service and, in 1916, to form the National Conservation Commission. Until his death in 1914, Muir continued to advocate for the conservation of land such as Mount Rainier, which became a National Park in 1899.

Key works

1874 *Studies in the Sierra*

1901 *Our National Parks*

1911 *My First Summer in the Sierra*

Rain forest clearance

Despite covering only 6 percent of Earth’s land surface, tropical rainforests represent the greatest biomass of any terrestrial ecoregion, and are home to about 80 percent of land species. Every year, some 54,000 sq miles (140,000 sq km) of tropical rainforest is cleared—the equivalent of a soccer